



THE APERTURE METHOD™ · CLASSROOM PROGRAM

# Business Cards

Six businesses, six different problems

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*The question this answers: **What is actually holding this business back?***

PREPARED FOR

**Grades 8–12**

The Woodlands, Texas

Set of Six · Edition One · The Aperture Method™

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**A NOTE ON THE BUSINESSES** — Every business in this packet is invented. The streets, parks and shopping centers are real places in The Woodlands, Texas, so the exercise feels like home — but no real business is described, and no real numbers are used.

## HOW TO USE THESE

## Six businesses

One card per team. Everything a team needs to find the answer is printed on the card — there is no missing information and no trick.

Each business has exactly one thing holding it back, and each of the six is held back by something different. Print single-sided, one business per page. Cardstock if the copier will take it.

| # | Business                | Where                                                                                                           | What is really wrong (facilitator only) |
|---|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1 | Waterway Waffle Co.     | walk-up window on The Woodlands Waterway, a two-minute walk from Town Green Park                                | THE THING                               |
| 2 | Creekside Cuts          | barbershop in a shopping center at Creekside Park Village Green                                                 | WHO                                     |
| 3 | Panther Creek Lawn Crew | yards around Panther Creek and Cochran's Crossing                                                               | MONEY                                   |
| 4 | Alden Bridge Bakehouse  | bakery in a strip center off Research Forest Drive, in the Village of Alden Bridge                              | WHO DOES THE WORK                       |
| 5 | Town Green Smoothie Bar | small shop steps from Town Green Park, in sight of the Cynthia Woods Mitchell Pavilion                          | WHERE & WHEN                            |
| 6 | Kickback Sneakers       | resale shop on the SECOND floor of a building off Six Pines Drive, above a nail salon. No sign at street level. | WHO                                     |

**Do not hand out this page**

The table above names the answer. Print pages 2 onward for students.

## BUSINESS 1 OF 6

# Waterway Waffle Co.

**WHERE** A walk-up window on The Woodlands Waterway, a two-minute walk from Town Green Park

**WHAT** Belgian waffles, coffee and fresh orange juice. Open every day, 7:00am to 2:00pm.

**What we know**

- A waffle sells for \$8. The batter, butter and toppings cost \$2.
- They own ONE waffle iron. One waffle takes 4 minutes to cook.
- Two people work the window: one takes orders, one cooks.
- The rush is Saturday and Sunday, 8:00am to 10:00am. The line goes out to the sidewalk.
- Last Saturday they sold 90 waffles.
- Last Saturday the person taking orders counted 40 people who stood in line, waited, and then left without buying anything.
- Rent, wages, power and supplies come to \$1,900 a week.
- Their reviews are 4.7 stars. People love the waffles.

**Your job**

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

Point to the fact on this card that proves it. Then say what you would do about it — and what it would be worth.

## BUSINESS 2 OF 6

# Creekside Cuts

**WHERE** A barbershop in a shopping center at Creekside Park Village Green

**WHAT** Haircuts, fades and beard trims. Four barbers. Open Tuesday through Saturday.

**What we know**

- A haircut is \$30.
- Last year, 2,400 different people got a haircut here.
- Of those 2,400 people, 1,560 came exactly one time and never came back.
- The other 840 came back again and again — an average of 6 times over the year.
- The shop spends \$900 a month on ads to bring in new people.
- Reviews average 4.6 stars. The barbers are good and everyone says so.
- Nobody at the shop has ever called, texted or emailed a customer after their haircut.

**Your job**

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

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## BUSINESS 3 OF 6

# Panther Creek Lawn Crew

**WHERE** Mowing yards around Panther Creek and Cochran's Crossing

**WHAT** Two high-school seniors, Dev and Ray, mow lawns on Saturdays. They pay a friend to help.

**What we know**

- They charge \$35 a yard. They have charged \$35 since the day they started, two years ago.
- Each yard takes about 45 minutes with three people working.
- Costs per yard: gas for the mowers \$4, gas for the truck \$3, blades and wear \$2. That is \$9 a yard.
- They pay their friend Marcus \$15 an hour, and he is with them the whole route.
- They do 8 yards on a Saturday, working 8:00am to 4:00pm — eight hours, including driving between houses.
- Every single customer has said yes. Nobody has ever said the price was too high.
- They have a waiting list of 5 more houses they do not have time for.

**Your job**

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## BUSINESS 4 OF 6

# Alden Bridge Bakehouse

**WHERE** A bakery in a strip center off Research Forest Drive, in the Village of Alden Bridge

**WHAT** Coffee and pastries for walk-ins, plus custom decorated cakes ordered ahead.

**What we know**

- A pastry sells for \$4 and costs \$1.20 to make.
- A custom cake sells for \$95, costs \$22 in ingredients, and takes 3 hours to decorate.
- Maria, the owner, is the ONLY person in the building who can decorate a cake.
- Maria also works the register, orders the supplies, does the schedule and locks up at night.
- Three other employees can bake, clean and run the register. None of them has ever been taught to decorate.
- Last month the shop turned down 14 cake orders. The reason written on every one: "Maria didn't have time."
- There is no waiting list problem for pastries. They never run out.

**Your job**

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

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## BUSINESS 5 OF 6

# Town Green Smoothie Bar

**WHERE** A small shop steps from Town Green Park, in sight of the Cynthia Woods Mitchell Pavilion

**WHAT** Smoothies, açai bowls and iced coffee.

**What we know**

- A smoothie sells for \$9. The fruit, milk and cup cost \$2.70.
- They are open Monday through Friday, 9:00am to 5:00pm. Closed Saturday and Sunday. Closed every evening.
- A normal weekday brings in about \$340.
- The Pavilion next door hosts more than 60 concerts a year, mostly Friday and Saturday nights.
- An average concert draws about 12,000 people, and most of them walk past this shop to get there.
- On concert nights, this shop is dark and locked.
- A hiring sign has been in the window for two months. They have not called anyone back.

**Your job**

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## BUSINESS 6 OF 6

# Kickback Sneakers

**WHERE** A resale shop on the SECOND floor of a building off Six Pines Drive, above a nail salon. No sign at street level.

**WHAT** Buys, sells and trades used and rare sneakers.

## What we know

- A pair sells for about \$120. They pay about \$70 for it. That is \$50 profit a pair.
- They sell 45 pairs a month.
- Reviews: 4.9 stars from 61 people. Customers describe the owner as the person who knows more about sneakers than anyone in Montgomery County.
- The shop has NO Instagram account, NO TikTok, and no posts anywhere. Not one.
- When asked how they found the shop, customers said: 70% "a friend told me," 25% "I saw the sign upstairs," 5% "Google."
- More than 7,000 high-school students live within four miles of the door.
- Nothing is wrong with the prices, the product, the staff or the hours.

## Your job

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